thorns. He also spent many hours watching pigeons fly, running alongside dogs, hunting deer and, as witnessed by one of his alarmed father's amirs, sleeping on the open ground. The impression of the young Akbar at this stage was of a robust, strong-willed, and easily distracted child filled with vital, restless energy and exulting in the wildness around him.

As a result of this unfettered, exuberant childhood spent avoiding his long-suffering tutors and running through the countryside in the raucous company of his kokas, Aziz, Zain, and Adham, Akbar grew up effectively illiterate. This was a perplexing reality in a man who would later own a fortune in manuscripts and who would orchestrate the largest translation and writing project undertaken at the time. It was certainly not for want of opportunity, for Aziz Koka, who was brought up alongside Akbar, grew up to be an erudite, literary, and extremely well-read man. Abu'l Fazl would explain the inconsistency through a miraculous, divine filter, comparing Akbar to the Prophet Muhammad, who was also illiterate. Akbar, too, would encourage parents to keep one of their children in a state of illiteracy, in imitation of the Prophet. That Akbar was a distracted, volatile child, who found it difficult to focus on the onerous task of a demanding Mughal education, is clear but there was one creative skill he was able to acquire, one that required as much concentration and physical immobility as learning grammar or history or religious studies, and that was painting. While he was in Kabul, Akbar learnt to paint from Abd al-Samad, and there is a rare miniature from the reign of Humayun which depicts this momentous event, when Akbar is shown presenting a painting he has made to his father. For this the young boy would have had to sit on his haunches, one leg folded under his body, his drawing board resting on his raised thigh, for hours at a time. So it would appear that Akbar was quite capable of sustained periods of applied work when it came to painting. His illiteracy, therefore, has been understood by modern scholars as being due to a dyslexic condition, which would appear to best explain why Akbar was able to paint and yet, in a court which valued writing and calligraphy so highly, was unable to write. In the sixteenth century, and at the mystically charged moment of the second Islamic millennium, this supposed illiteracy would not be deemed a failing but would be interpreted by Abu'l Fazl as further proof of the Padshah's grandeur, of his being quite beyond the limitations of ordinary mortals.